

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world

Social Consciousness

stream and downstream, passing information at a frenetic pace from their eyes, nose, and ears to the cortices of the brain which eventually generate consciousness. Together they form the mega-brain of the nation that is social consciousness: the simple yet powerful realisation that we can be the change we want. The time is here, not just in India and in Brazil and in developing countries which have suffered from sub-par governance and self-aggrandising politicians, but even, as the Obama election showed, in a developed country like the US.

It could be that the world has suddenly become more socially conscious; that citizens everywhere have decided to reinvent democracy and bootstrap it to its original charter. It could be that in India and many other parts of the world the demographics

INTENSE MEDIA SCRUTINY LED TO THE CONVICTION OF NITISH KATARA'S KILLERS



MERELY CHANGING PARTIES and leaders every election hasn't helped. Vote for the party which empowers you rather than empowers itself.

ARVIND KEJRIWAL,
RTI ACTIVIST AND
MAGSAYSAY AWARD WINNER

are heavily tilted in favour of youth, and hence, idealism and action. It could be that the Internet and the freedom that began to flourish, thanks to it in the final decade of the last century, fuelled the fire in the first decade of this one for a deeper and more profound self-liberation. A fire that finds its inspiration as well as strategic sustenance from a movement that might be taking place at another end of the earth. Maybe information really is power and we are seeing the empowerment unleashed by the technologies of the late 20th century now in the 21st: real time global connectivity in urban India and the full impact of the TV revolution in rural India. The spread of cable TV in many parts of the world has been linked to lower birth rates, greater independence among women, and a decreased rate of drug use among youth. The paradigm shift from a state-owned TV channel to multiple private networks introduced the possibility of greater transparency at many levels of governance. It also gave viewers a peep into other lives and other possibilities. The Internet takes this one step further, making every individual a part of the vibrating virtual consciousness that hums; we are each a synapse of the connective brain. This fact has been mapped out by social networking which shows us how many degrees removed we are from each other and demonstrated by the power of contagion in viral videos. Twitter takes the web even further; activists tweet real time information to others in their group during demonstration and marches; during the Iranian election it allowed news to get out to the world. The smart people in politics who understand its reach can use it as a more direct tool for governance, not just activism. Minister of State for External Affairs, Shashi Tharoor has over 4,00,000 followers at the time of writing this article.

Of course, the picture is not always rosy. For example, at the level of the mass media and the role it plays when it mirrors the desires of the public, there is much to be criticised. Does the soundbyte approach to justice cause more harm than good? The kind of mobilisation that is generated when the media takes up a popular cause and runs with it is nonetheless subject to viewer ratings. Without the vision of leadership it seems like social consciousness is unable to sustain its energy and develop as profoundly as it needs to; the public wants only

THERE ISN'T A SINGLE authority that works responsibly, which is why people protest.

ADOLF D'SOUZA,
CITIZEN ACTIVIST

Civic SENSE

2000 After public pressure, the CBI challenges the acquittal of Santosh Singh, prime accused in the Priyadarshini Mattoo rape and murder case, in the Delhi High Court.

2002 Delhi Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit launches the Bhagidaari scheme to promote citizen-government partnership.

2005 The RTI Act, giving ordinary citizens the right to question the government, introduced. The Central Information Commission is constituted.

2006 Manu Sharma held guilty for Jessica's murder. A similar public outrage in 2008 ensures that Nitish Katara's killers too are punished.

2008 The 26/11 terror attacks has the Mumbai elite rushing out of their drawing rooms to the streets.

2009 The Delhi High Court overturns the ban on gay sex.